



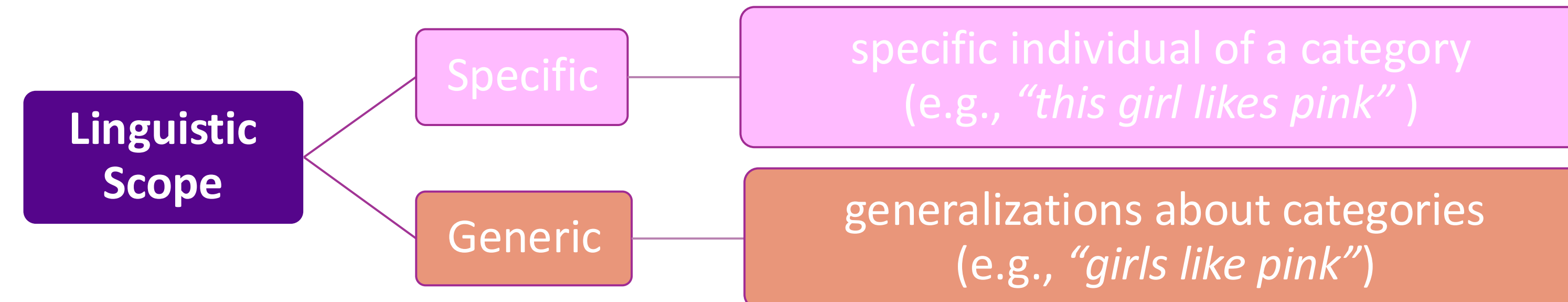
Linguistic Scope Matters: Children's Responses to Parental Gendered Language

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1 BACKGROUND

- Early gender concept development is especially sensitive to linguistic scope.¹

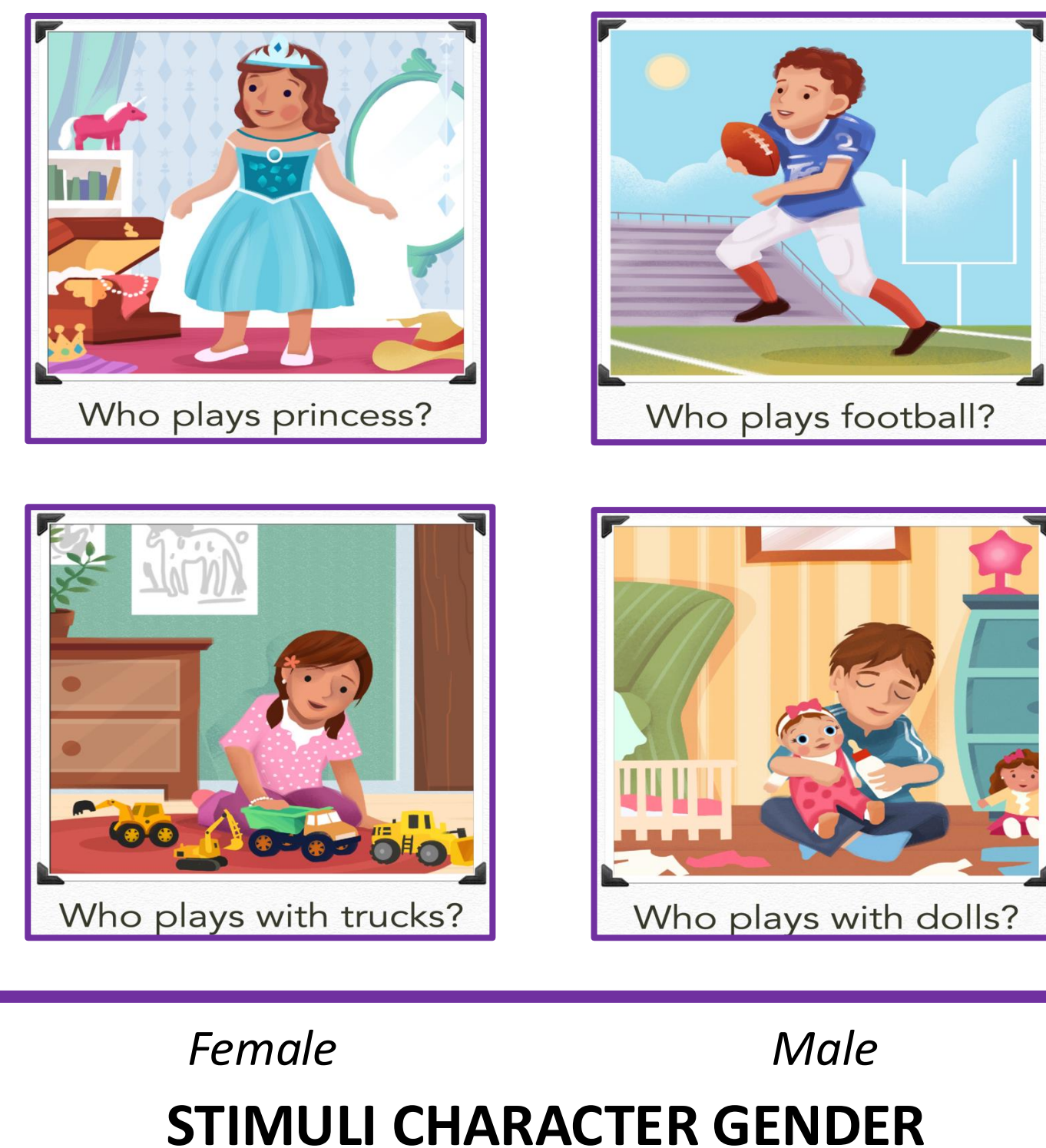


- Exposure to generics often promotes essentialist beliefs, leading children to view social groups as homogeneous and to infer that group members share inherent traits that are universal and immutable.²⁻⁴
 - This pattern of reasoning is problematic because it can facilitate inaccurate generalizations.
- Most research examines parents' production of gender generics, but far less is known about how children respond to those statements in real time.

OBJECTIVE: To test whether children respond differently to parental gender statements depending on whether those statements are framed as generic versus specific, and whether stimuli type matters.

2 METHODS

STIMULI STEREOTYPE CONSISTENCY



PROCEDURE:

- 129 parent-child dyads (children ages 3–6; $M_{\text{age}} = 4.5$) completed a naturalistic storybook reading session via our lab's virtual, unmoderated platform, PANDA.
- Parents discussed prompts about the depicted character's actions with their child.
 - Half of the actions were gender stereotype consistent, and the other half were stereotype inconsistent.
- Parents then self-uploaded the recorded videos, which were transcribed and coded.⁵

3 LINGUISTIC CODING

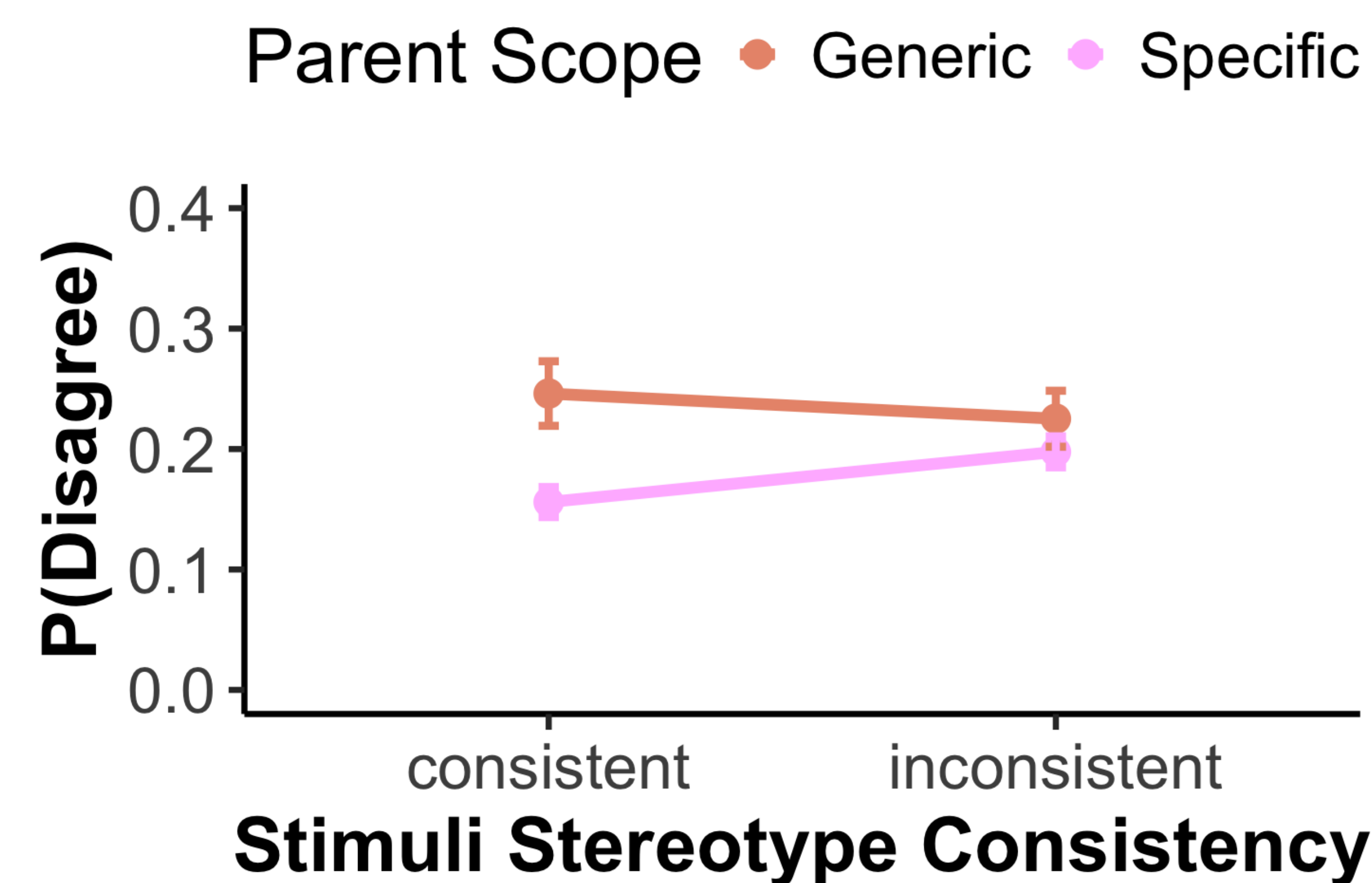
- Parent language was previously coded for gender generic and specific statements.¹
- We focused on children's immediate responses to parents' gender generic and specific statements (see Table 1).

Table 1. Coding scheme for children's immediate response to parent's gender generic and specific statements

Agree			Disagree			Neutral
Explicit	Implicit	Thematic	Explicit	Implicit	Thematic	
Direct assent ("Yes," "Yeah," "Uh-huh")	Shows assent via repetition ("Boys play football") or elaboration ("And soccer too!")	Echoes same gender referent (Parent: "Boys play football." Child: "Boys run fast!")	Direct rejection ("No," "No way")	Challenges via correction ("Girls can too!") or contrast ("Some girls play football"), or exception ("Not all boys!")	Invokes opposite gender or inclusivity (Parent: "Boys play football." Child: "Girls play sports!")	No stance or unrelated content ("Can we go outside?")

4 RESULTS

Figure 1. Children were less likely to disagree with specific statements than generics, especially when the stimuli were stereotype-consistent



- Significant associations between **parental linguistic scope**, **stimulus stereotypicality**, and **children's stance-taking** ($\chi^2(14) = 46.50$, $p = .0076$).
- Stimulus character gender **did not independently predict** children's stance-taking.

5 DISCUSSION

- Children were less likely to disagree with specific statements than generic ones, suggesting children are particularly sensitive to scope when content aligns with existing stereotypes.
 - Possible explanation: specific language cues children to think about an individual rather than a broad category → therefore, children may map specific statements onto real people or observations, making them less likely to disagree.

BIG TAKEAWAY: Children are **not** passive recipients of gendered input.

- They evaluate parental statements and adjust their responses based on **both parental linguistic scope and stereotypicality of the content**.
- Therefore, gender beliefs are actively negotiated in parent-child interactions, revealing a possible nuanced pathway through which linguistic input can reinforce or challenge early gender norms.

6 REFERENCES

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